death. He spent the following day in great anguish, and his writings show that he regretted taking a life. One of the Lahore Conspiracy accused later wrote how ‘Bhagat Singh remained upset for some days’ [3] after the murder. To him, violence was justified but only when it was a matter of moral necessity.

No one recognized this more clearly than Jawaharlal Nehru. He wrote, ‘Bhagat Singh did not become popular because of his act of terrorism, but because he seemed to vindicate, for the moment, the honour of Lala Lajpat Rai; and through him of the nation.’ This is why, ‘[w]ithin a few months, each town and village of the Punjab and to a lesser extent in the rest of northern India, resounded with Bhagat Singh’s name’ so that, ‘[i]nnumerable songs grew up about him, and the popularity that the man achieved, was something amazing’. [4]

Asaf Ali, his one-time lawyer who went on to become independent India’s first ambassador to the USA, explained how after interviewing Bhagat Singh, he ‘found him extremely human and gentle’ being ‘one of the gentlest and the most affectionate in temperament, the very antithesis of a hard and blood-thirsty revolutionary’ so that ‘had he been spared he would have been an outstanding personality in any field of life’. [5] Jaidev Gupta, Bhagat Singh’s friend, also attested to his gentleness when he recalled much later that, ‘had you the fortune of seeing him you would have never forgotten the broad charming smile and pleasing manners with which he would have received you’.

We can compare such impeccable moral coherence of Bhagat Singh’s outlook with that of Mahatma Gandhi’s doctrinaire belief in non-violent satyagraha at all costs. Gandhi insisted on non-violence even when it made no sense. This is why in the long run it did not work and he had to give it up. Nothing illustrates this better than the violent Chauri Chaura incident of 1922 in Uttar Pradesh. A large group of volunteers were participating in a protest against high food prices. The group was part of the non-cooperation movement of Mahatma Gandhi himself. During the protest, however, the police overreacted. They beat up the demonstrators and arrested their leaders. Then they locked them up at the Chauri Chaura police station. Two